



Battle-tested: The Indian men's squad retained the core from the team that stunned 14-time champion Indonesia in the final four years ago — Lakshya, Kidambi Srikanth, H. S. Prannoy and the Satwik-Chirag pair. PICS: GETTY IMAGES

A few hours before the contest, India suffered a huge blow with World No. 11 Lakshya being ruled out due to a swollen elbow, the result of multiple dives during his battle with Chou.

The French team's combination also took Satwik-Chirag out of the picture. With the Popov brothers, Christo and Toma Junior — its No. 1 and No. 3 singles players — also forming its top doubles pair, the match order had to be determined in a way that allowed them enough time to rest and recover between matches. Therefore, the sprightly Satwik-Chirag duo could only be in action if the tie went the distance.

It never reached that stage as France swept aside India 3-0. World No. 4 Christo outplayed Ayush, India's best singles player in Lakshya's absence, 21-11, 21-9. World No. 10 Alex Lanier took down Srikanth 21-16, 21-18, and Toma Junior wrapped up the tie with a 21-19, 21-16 victory over Prannoy.

Srikanth and Prannoy were selected as India's third and fourth best singles players in the BWF rankings, but both are 33. It raises obvious questions about the growth

of young shuttlers in the country. What happened to someone like Priyanshu Rajawat, who was part of the 2022 squad and went on to win a Super 300 title in 2023? Does the country lack bench strength? Are there enough top-quality coaches to train future stars?

Even in doubles, Indian duos other than Satwik-Chirag are yet to step up to the next level.

The situation is not too different for the women's team, which failed to progress to the quarterfinals after losses to China and Denmark in the group stage of the Uber Cup. P. V. Sindhu is still expected to do the heavy lifting while the youngsters adapt to the highest level of professional badminton.

With the Asian Games set to take place later this year, these are some of the issues the Badminton Association of India will have to address.

The process appears to have begun, with the federation releasing an advertisement on April 29 seeking "highly qualified and experienced Indian coaches" to train players at centres in Hyderabad, Bengaluru and Guwahati.

Honour board



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UBER CUP FINAL

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MEDALLISTS

Thomas Cup

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Silver – France

Bronze – India, Denmark

Uber Cup

Gold – Korea

Silver – China

Bronze – Japan, Indonesia

